

That Has Been

Encountering the Grand Canyon



“The studium is a kind of general, enthusiastic commitment.”

Grand Canyon, Arizona. Photograph by Michael Dolessandro,

The Grand Canyon first presents itself as spectacle. Its vastness invites admiration, geology, history, tourism. I recognize it culturally as landmark, monument, symbol. This is what Barthes calls the studium: a shared field of interest, something I have been trained to see and appreciate.

“A photograph’s punctum is that accident which pricks me (but also bruises me, is poignant to me).”

It is not the canyon’s immersivity that captures me, but the fragile branch leaning over the abyss. It feels temporary against something ancient. Barthes writes that the punctum “shoots out of the scene like an arrow”. For me, it is the tension between persistence and vulnerability.

Works Cited

Barthes, Roland. *Camera Lucida: Reflections on Photography*. Translated by Richard Howard, Hill and Wang, 1981.



Grand Canyon, Arizona. Photograph by Michael Dolessandro,